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Carmen Caramanica

Guitarist Carmen Caramanica's skills as a guitarist and teacher are legendary in Central New York. His versatility as a performer and musical director have enabled him to achieve success far beyond his home town of Utica, NY.

Carmen was interviewed at his studio in New Hartford, New York, on July 27, 2011, by Monk Rowe, director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I am off-camera at Carmen Caramanica's studio in Utica, New York, and I'm very happy to have him here as a guest for the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College. Hey Carmen. We go back a long ways.

CC: Oh yeah.

MR: And I have to tell you that my graduate school, after I got out of Fredonia, was playing with you and Rick [Montalbano] and Dolores [Mancuso], and I forget the drummer's name.

CC: Joe DePalma.

MR: Joe DePalma. Of course he was Joey Dee, right?

CC: Yeah.

MR: On that gig at The Beeches. And I might as well ask you about that now, and I want to go back even further, but I thought when I got out of Fredonia after four years that I knew a lot about music. But then I started playing that gig and I found that I didn't really know anything about playing a gig. And you and Rick Montalbano seemed to know all that stuff. And I'm curious as to why did you know the tunes to play and what worked in that situation? Where did that knowledge come from?

CC: How did we know what tunes to play?

MR: Well how did you know how to handle that particular gig, which was just a restaurant and people would dance. But where did you learn to do that?

CC: Well you know I think that's a good question. Historically if you look at what was happening in the sixties, it wasn't so much — we had a radio station format that was all metal, it was all classic rock, it was all jazz, it was all country, it was all whatever. There were so many different kinds of music out there that appealed to so many different kinds of people, if you wanted to play a gig you had to know how to play a country tune with an authentic country feel, or a polka or, you know, any kind of thing. And of course we were in jazz so you had to listen to jazz. Well if you study enough of that kind of music, and I don't mean like formally study but just like learn tunes and check them out, and you develop your ear, you have the ability to play just about anything that sounded authentic. So a new tune comes along and you say okay well that's a little of this and a little of that,

and I can do it. So you're not just stuck with I can only play this style or that style. So I think that's kind of what we had going for us. If you wanted to work, you had to be able to play whatever's on the radio, and it could be any style.

MR: Yes. And the radio, I remember recently looking at Billboard's Top 10 from back in those years, and it was so varied. You could go from an Elvis song number one, and number two might be Mitch Miller. I mean, and the same playlist.

CC: Right. And Sinatra with Basie. Yeah. All that Top 40 or whatever, it was very diversified. That changed a lot. And I think you mentioned in some of the pre-questions you gave me of things to think about, what to tell younger students who are interested in becoming musicians. And I want to skip to that because it goes right along with what we're talking about is diversification of styles, learning more about not only how to play your instrument but, as much as I love jazz, there are other elements of music that make up that whole genre of jazz. And we've got the blues and we've got ballads and we've got big band stuff, and you've got chord and melody things in terms of the guitar, and the kids don't study this. They say "I like Avenged Seven" I'm going to use these kinds of styles and sounds. And then when the music changes, as it will, it evolves, some other style comes in and they're not aware of how to do that. You say if you want to be good at what you're doing, diversify.

MR: Okay. So you listened to the radio at that time, and you picked out tunes that you liked, or tunes that you may not have liked and you played them anyway.

CC: Right.

MR: Okay. I heard, because I'm not from this area, I didn't quite know you a real long time ago. I heard something about George Dell, the music store owner, visiting you when you were laid up or something, to give you a start. Is that true?

CC: Oh yeah, yeah. What happened, as a child I had a problem with my hip. And so I was in the hospital for an extended period of time while they were finding different surgeries and therapies to try to get me to be able to walk. As a result I was in the hospital for more than three years, without going home. And this happened at the time I was between nine and eleven or something like that. So to try to give me something to do, one of my aunts brought me a little plastic ukulele and I'm sitting there figuring stuff out on it. And I said hey this is pretty cool. I've got an old guitar in the attic, let me dig that out. And so they brought me this old horrible guitar. And by myself I was just messing around, it was a toy to me, I was figuring stuff out. So it got noticed by the people in the hospital and they said well we need a teacher to come in to give this kid something to do so he stops terrorizing the nurses. So the bottom line is the guy that came over to teach me was originally a studio guitarist, I believe for CBS in New York, his name was George O'Dell, he called himself George Dell, and he had a band called the Dell Trio. Well when

he retired from professional music in New York, he came back to his wife's home town which was Utica, and the wife used to be a nurse at what is now Faxton Hospital, then it was Children's Hospital. So they called her and said hey, your husband teaches? You want to send him up and teach this kid we got? And so he would come up and give me a half hour lesson. However, his wife would be in the nurse's lounge having coffee, talking to her old cronies, and the half hour lesson would become 45 minutes, an hour, an hour and a half. So as long as she kept chatting he kept giving me longer and longer lessons. It was great for me I had nothing else to do. So I had this really good conscientious teacher that loved to talk, and I was as fond of eating it up. So that's how I got my start.

MR: Were your parents happy to see this going on?

CC: Were they what?

MR: Were your parents happy to see this going on?

CC: Oh absolutely. Anything from keeping me from being a crazy kid.

MR: Yeah. Well it must have been hard. Did you have tutors coming in too?

CC: At that time they actually had a school room, so they had a one room schoolhouse kind of situation so I still kept up my studies.

MR: And was there a point in your life that you said hey, this could be my career?

CC: You know I think I've always felt that, even though, in high school when I thought I wanted to go into music, I talked to my counselor who said "well you can't major in guitar, there is no school that does that." Of course this was wrong because I graduated in 1964. Berklee was already in existence. There were places in the southern part of the United States that had guitar majors. This man was just unaware of that. This was pre-Internet, pre-communications. He didn't know. So he said "well you can either major in another instrument or do something else." So I went to my next strongest subject which was communication, and I majored in English at Utica College. And then halfway through my sophomore year I got an offer to go on the road with a musician and — no contest. I just dropped out.

MR: With whom?

CC: Jimmy Cavallo and the House Rockers.

MR: Oh yeah. I'll be darned. Okay, and what was that gig like for you?

CC: Oh it was very interesting. Talk about diversity. I played for him a little bit and he said "oh this is great I'm going to give you a reel to reel tape of our show, and I want you to figure it out." There's no music, no charts, nothing. "I want you to figure out what we're doing and we'll have a rehearsal next Thursday" or whatever, like that. And the gig was guitar, bass and drums, and Jimmy sang and played sax. So the charts were everything from Sinatra charts, the orchestration Basie things, that stuff; to soul rock, because he was a rocker; jazz things like [I Got] Rhythm changes, where he'd just go off honking in

the audience for twenty minutes and then we'd get to keep that going; and so I had to figure all of that stuff out and cover as many parts of it as I could as a guitar player, trying to play horn parts and everything, and still keep the rhythm going. So it was kind of interesting. Somehow I got the gig. And my first gig on the road was in Baltimore. And we played this huge club, they had like three floors with a bar on every floor and there were people dancing and it was like a massive type of thing. And there's kind of a funny war story there, Rhythm changes, as you know, it's 16 bars and then you've got the bridge, and then you go back to 8 bars. Well if you do that three, four, five times, you begin to wonder, have I done the first 16 here, or do I have to go again? Now, Jimmy would like jump off the stage, with his saxophone, and he'd be jamming and playing, and he would hop on to these tables. And people would be drinking. And he's over there dancing on the tables honking the saxophone at them. Right? And he's getting further and further and further away from the band. Meanwhile we're just kind of [scats] and this thing is going on and on and on. And probably about the 20th or 30th chorus, I'm lost. I don't know where I am. I came in with the bridge at the wrong time or something like that. And somebody yells "no you're at the wrong spot." So Jimmy realizes this is a problem, so he decides to come back to the stage, gets on the stage, continues to play, puts his saxophone right into my ear and honks the root, telling me where I should be. Loud. So it was a very hard lesson to learn. Don't get lost. Keep track of the tune. That was an embarrassing moment. But I did learn a lot from the Cavallo band. We did all kinds of gigs, we played in the Amish country. Imagine playing a jazz gig in Lenox, Pennsylvania or York, Pennsylvania. We did these things. Things like — very strange stuff. We also played Atlantic City and some better gigs. But basically he was a rocker that had blues and jazz roots. And he's still out there. I think he's about eighty-something years old and still playing.

MR: Do you remember what you made?

CC: Oh yeah. I think we got like $150 a week. Out of that we had to pay for expenses. We had to pay for rooms, we doubled up, pay for your food.

MR: You know I don't think I've ever met a musician in the early part of their career that got their own motel room.

CC: It finally happened by the time I got some better gigs.

MR: Yeah, a little higher up. Talk about learning on the job, that's great. Well okay and you did that for a while and you came back here. How do you get, how did the channels open up for you that eventually got you to the next level up?

CC: Well after I left Jimmy Cavallo's band, the bass player and I actually left together and formed a trio, and we picked up a drummer in Atlantic City where we were working, his name was Jack Toker, a wonderful drummer. And Jack and I and the bass player had a

group for about six months and that fell apart and I said okay, I decided I was going to come home, and the drummer said he was going to stay out on the road. Well he hooked up with a show band at that time, and this must have been '69, '70, right around that time. There were lots of gigs and so you could play the Holiday Inn circuit, you could keep working, again, covering songs on the radio, this stuff. So he got into a group that was pretty good about this, and they were all over the country. So he happened to land a gig in Seattle at a place called, I believe, the Trojan Horse was the name of it. And there were two rooms. There was a show room that had major acts, and then there was a smaller room which was a lounge, and that's where they were playing, in this little lounge. So Lou Rawls had just come back from a European tour. He had lost his musical director so he picked up a guy in London named Reggie Powell, who had a degree from the Royal College of Music, he studied with Sir Richard Thomas Beecham, orchestration. He was a pretty cool guy. Plus he played great jazz piano and organ. So he became Lou's musical director. Lou imported him into the U.S. Now not knowing anybody in the U.S., this guy, going into the lounge after a show, sees this band playing and having a drink, and my friend the drummer Jack Toker playing the gig. And he says "this guy's pretty good." So after their show he goes "hey, my name is Reg Powell and I'm in the other room there with Lou, and you know, I'd like to get your number because I like the way you play, and we may need a drummer sometime, you never know. I don't know anybody in the States." And Jack says "right." So he gives him his phone number. And they became fast friends. I guess they were there for a month or something and they would jam in the afternoons, so they became fast friends musically and otherwise. So I get a phone call from Jack Toker and he says you're never going to believe this, I'm gigging with Lou Rawls. Now at the time, Lou had just come off a hit called "A Natural Man" which everybody knew who he was, prior to that he had had jazz hits and so he was a jazz, blues, pop singer and working with him was a big deal. So I was very happy for him. So he said "look, we're going to be in New York at the St. Regis Hotel. Why don't you come down and put your guitar in the trunk. Come down and see the show and I'd like you to meet this piano player, you're going to like him." Okay fine. So I went down, I saw the show, met Lou Rawls, the first time I'd met a star. And the next afternoon we went down to the showroom which was closed, and the three of us played, piano, guitar and drums, and Reggie Powell says to me "hey, I like the way you play, why don't you give me your phone number?" Déjà vu again. So that's what happened. And a few months later we got called. Actually this is a side story that goes along with it. I was in another band, a local band, trying to get things going. And we had a trumpet player who was from New York. I'll leave his name out, he might see this. But we had a trumpet player who was from New York, a very arrogant guy, a wonderful trumpet player but

arrogant. And he was always breaking my chops because we said my friend Jack Toker is playing with Lou Rawls and I got a postcard from them and they're going to be going to Europe. Oh wonderful. And so he would always say things to me like "well gee maybe Lou Rawls is going to call you up to play this gig in Frankfort" or something like that. And I said "well that'd be nice." And so one time we were rehearsing and the phone rings. And he said "hey answer that it's probably Lou Rawls." And it was. And I said oh man, "oh yes, Mr. Rawls, oh thank you, oh call you Lou?" You know, that kind of stuff. And everybody is sitting there and the trumpet player is going "what's going on?" And he basically offered me the gig. He said "I'd like you to come and play with us, we're going to be starting and we're going to Miami for two weeks and then we're going to go to Los Angeles and we're going to do this" and he's telling me his itinerary. "Do you think you could make it?" And I said "oh very much so. Listen, before you go, could you please say hello to a friend of mine?" And I handed him the phone, and this guy just — did one of those kind of numbers. So it was one of those small victories in life that, you know you never believe something like this is going to happen. So I said oh that's great.

MR: Yeah. And it's so cool because Lou Rawls, he had such a distinctive voice too? There no like pretending that this is —

CC: Oh yeah. The phone vibrated.

MR: That's great.

CC: So that's how I luckily got hooked up with Lou Rawls. And then to wrap up the story quickly, because I've told this before, after being with Lou for about six months, the musical director who had gotten me into this gig decided he was going to go home to England. And so he suggested me to be the musical director in his place. It's a little bit on the unheard of side, because basically I had no credentials. I didn't have a college education, I didn't have a lot of experience, I mean professional experience, other than being a guitar player on this gig and the duties of a musical director, I know you're going to ask me that later — it's a nice list that you gave me because it gives me some time to think about it — you have to write the arrangements for the band. And I wasn't trained in orchestration. I bought books, I did a correspondence course from Berklee. It was a six month course where they would send you assignments and you sent them back and they'd correct it, and my teacher after two or three lessons stopped sending the stuff back so I just kind of did it on my own. Luckily there were some people around here, the late Chic Esposito was wonderful. I would go to him with my scores and say "Chic, did I do this right?" and he'd say "no, the saxophone doesn't have that note on his horn" things like that. You know, "check your range." He would do all kinds of nice tutoring for me. So that was wonderful. And there were other people around that I could talk to that kind of helped me too. But basically it was still by the seat of my pants that I was doing this stuff.

But I did watch how Reg conducted the band and talked to him about how he wrote things, and he was also a wonderful mentor to me. He exposed me to stuff that I'd never thought of. So he said "look, just take the gig. If it doesn't work out for you then you can go back to being the guitar player. They're not going to fire you, and they'll get another musical director or arranger." Okay fine. So I did it. And the first assignment I got was well we're going to do "The Tonight Show." And we need two charts that we don't have, for Lou to sing on this thing. And so here's Shelly Cohen's number. Shelly Cohen was the musical director for "The Tonight Show." Doc Severinsen was the conductor and Tommy Newsome was the second director. But when you dealt with the Tonight Show Band you dealt with Shelly Cohen, who did everything from music clearance to telling you what you need, and so we had a situation where we were going to do something that called for strings and he said "well the budget for this particular act doesn't call for strings so can you do it for flutes instead?" So he would have this whole system that he would work out, the whole politics of it. So that was my first time I had to do something, and actually score it for a professional band. I'd done some smaller bands around here, but this was like oh boy. So I brought my little keyboard into the hotel rooms, and I sweated blood over every note until I finally got everything to be "I think this worked. Let me try this again. Let me play this again."

MR: Because there was no — this was like way pre-Finale days where you could hear it back.

CC: Oh absolutely. You could not hear a thing. You had to go "let's see, here's how I voiced the brass, okay that's right." Of course I can't play keyboard worth anything anyway so everything was for slow motion. Now the saxes under that, yeah that should work. Now do I really want? No don't do that. This kind of thing. So I somehow got through writing these things to the point where I thought I think they're going to work and of course I was very familiar with the style because by this time I'd been playing with Lou and I knew the kind of stuff he liked to hear, I knew his history. So in any event, we got to the rehearsal and all I had to do was go one-two-three-four, and this wonderful band kicked in and it was like — bong — this sounded so cool. It was like amazing. You know everything worked. And when you have wonderful musicians that do this every day, it's magic. And it makes you look really good.

MR: And you're kind of standing there like "yeah I knew this was going to work."

CC: I don't know, I think there was a little puddle of sweat by the time we did both songs. But it really came out nice. And then as kind of another little pat on the back, Doc Severinsen was on this particular show, and a lot of times he wasn't there and Tommy was there. But he said "when we do the break, let's give the guitar player some. So there was this, I don't know, some blues thing or something like that. And so they got to that section, and we'll be back in a few minutes. And so he points to me and I'm soloing with the Tonight

Show Band. For about ten seconds you heard it and then it faded out for a dog food commercial or something like that.

MR: But the audience was listening.

CC: Oh yeah.

MR: And this was on the west coast?

CC: This was on the west coast, right.

MR: After they moved. Wow that's a thrill.

CC: It was a thrill, yeah. It really worked out. I did learn a couple of other things along the way, in talking about what a musical director has to do. Sometimes you have to write a chart and you don't know what the band is going to be like. So when you're dealing with studio musicians or the LA Tonight Show Band or Vegas musicians, you can't lose, because no matter what you do, even if you screw up they fix it for you. I mean they're like really cool. But sometimes you get musicians that aren't quite as experienced, and if you write something that's too difficult to read, they don't want to play it. So you look at it this way, if you write a bunch of whole and half notes when you can get away with it, and maybe a few figures, guys are going to look at that and say hey, I can do this. And you give the rhythm section most of the stuff because they're rehearsed, they know what they're doing, and the rest of it is sweetening. So for road musicians, at least back in those days, if you do it that way you're going to have a pretty good show most of the time, even if they're musicians that don't get a chance to play that much — school teachers, whatever. In some towns, we had that situation in Buffalo. We played the Melody Fair in North Tonawanda. And the band was kind of like not really all that great. And so they had a couple of songs that they knew how to play by themselves, so they played the opening and then they kind of basically sat there tacet while we played the show self-contained, there was really maybe one or two charts that were real easy that they could do, and then they played the exit music, which was theirs, and that's kind of what we did. Because it was just too much. But the whole trick is if you can make it look easy enough, most of the time they can do it on site, you're going to be okay. If you make it look difficult you're going to have a band that's a little bit afraid to play the stuff and you're not going to get a committed performance out of them.

MR: Were you, did you have the responsibility of calling the local contractor yourself before you get to that town, or the manager did that or what?

CC: No. In terms of Lou Rawls' band there was a manager and a management company, and so all we had to do — and a travel agent and all that stuff. I mean in some bands you've got to do that too, you've got to call the airlines even. No this was, everything was handled, all we had to do was show up, and the hardest part of my job was carrying the

four boxes of music — this and this and this — and make sure that they didn't get lost with the airlines. We had situations where the music doesn't show up.

MR: Did you copy your own parts?

CC: Did I copy what?

MR: Did you copy your own parts at that time? Were you the copyist also?

CC: This is another interesting story. In the LA union, especially at that time, you got paid for writing an arrangement based on the so-called four bar page. So if you had a four piece thing or a whole orchestra, four bars, there was a rate for it. Right? So it could be anywhere from $4.75 for a rhythm section thing, to maybe $20 for a four bar page for a full orchestra or whatever. So whatever those rates were. And then you'd multiply those numbers and that's what you got paid as an arranger. The copyist, however, got paid way more than that, double and triple. Because first of all you give them a score in concert and he's got to transpose it, he's got to write it and his penmanship had to be absolutely wonderful. I mean if you've seen the way I write my name you won't want me copying any of your charts. And again, pre-Finale, pre-everything, so it had to be written just right. And then these guys got much more money for copying than the guy who actually wrote the chart. So there were times when we had to do something and the manager would say "well look we've got plenty of time, you want to do the copying yourself and make the extra bucks?" I said "yeah, sure." Right. And so I would, with a felt-tipped pen, you know, try to copy, very, very slowly and try to make it look good. Well if you're copying — our bands were basically big band style, we had four trumpets, three trombones, five saxes, rhythm section. Each one of those little parts copied by hand, you know, to somebody that's not a good copyist — so I did that once or twice. And I said I'm not doing this again. So I'll lose the money, let the copyist do it. And you know what else about copyists, they were so good, we did some recording sessions where we thought things were going to be in a certain key but the copyists were there anyway in another room at a table. And at some point they decided well let's change the key to this thing. So they'd say "okay, hang on, take a half hour break." And these dudes would be in there with the score and they'd say "up a minor third." "Right." And these guys would cook. And it looked wonderful. And there were a few parts they could put on onionskin and just xerox, but most of the other ones they had to write out one at a time. So that's how fast they were. Now with the computer, a key change — in fact the union in Los Angeles, there used to be, if they asked you to transpose on site there was a certain scale for that.

MR: Say that again?

CC: There was a different scale for transposition on site. So let's say you got the chart there and they say "well it's just a little low, can you bring it up a whole step?" "Okay, I can do that." And so they would pay you more because you transposed. There was also a scale

for, for guitar players. If you had to use various pedals, so if you had the wah wah pedal, if you had the distortion pedal, you know, it was a little bit more money for having those things if they called for them.

MR: Is that because — maybe it's both — they're paying you for the skill to use them, but also that you made the investment to have them.

CC: I think so. And the idea that there is a different sound. At one time the union was very, very strong, and they said "okay, you want this — you want classical guitar, that's a different instrument than a steel string guitar." Well, not really. You play it with your fingers. But anyway, so they got many little, and these weren't huge jumps, but they were enough so that it made a little bit of difference.

MR: I don't think the Utica musicians union ever had to go quite that far.

CC: No.

MR: I love those behind-the-scenes stories. And some of those skills, I mean I was thinking about the way you and I learned music, with our ear to the radio or to the record player, and these copyists doing that stuff. I will now sound old-fashioned, but those ways of learning are not around anymore that much.

CC: No. And it's too bad because people are losing a valuable skill. I teach guitar, and a lot of my students, if they want to learn a tune they go to the Internet and they download a tab [tablature], all right? So the music is not all music, but just numbers. But anyway, they listen to it, they see the numbers and they do that. And then they don't really develop any kind of ear, any kind of relative pitch, so they can't figure stuff out on their own, and then they say "I don't need to I can get the tab." And if it isn't out today it'll be out tomorrow, I'll get it. And so where's the development? Where is that whole thing? And it impedes their ability to improvise, see, especially on guitar, you've got the problem is we have patterns, and it's very visual. So when you first learn to improvise on the blues is where we start most kids that want to do that, they learn to put these little pentatonic patterns on the keyboard, on the fingerboard. And it's two notes on each string. And we'll say well okay mix them up. So they just kind of run up and down the scale and it kind of sounds like it works if you put a background track to it. But it takes a while before they begin to realize what the function of each one of those notes is, how it relates to the chord, when you should use the third, when you should go to something else. And they don't see this because they just look at the pattern and run it over and over and over again. Now when you try to compose something you have to like listen to what's going on in your mind and play what you're hearing, without hearing anything. They're just "oh that's what that sounds like, I see." And so you have to kind of go backwards and say well look, let's take a song you've never heard before, or that you've never played before. Let's do "Yankee Doodle." Put your first finger here. And now find the next three notes. And a lot of them

really don't know which way is up, which way is down. So we say "try singing the note when you're playing it." Okay. So they'll play and sing the first note and then "what's the next note?" and you make them sing it, and now where is that, it's over here. And so by doing this they start to sing what they play. And this goes back to another war story, which is when I first discovered that was a good way to develop the brain-instrument relationship so you're really playing what you're hearing not just what you think is going to sound good, you have to hear it first then play it, I sang everything. And it got to be a habit. Now if you've heard me sing, it's kind of like my writing, you don't want to hear much of it. So by playing and singing at the same time I was definitely connecting with my musical self inside the brain. But it got to the point where I was singing pretty loud while I was playing. And actually one time Rick Montalbano and I were doing a recording session and I was next to the piano, and we were playing and then we stopped and he said "hey you want to stop?" I said "stop what?" He says "you're grunting every note that you play and it's going to get into the mic of the piano." And he was right I was [grunts] doing that. And I know I kind of still do that today because sometimes I'll play a set and I'll get off and I feel hoarse because it's coming out.

MR: Well I've heard other people — Herb Ellis said the same thing. He said you should be singing — be able to sing what you want to play I guess. But he apparently did the same thing, he would sing along. So did you eventually get burned out with the road and being away?

CC: You know I did and I think a lot of it had to do with I kind of made a choice to become a career musician rather than a dedicated artist. And this is something that happens to a lot of people. If you're lucky enough to play the kind of music professionally that you want to play to the exclusion of everything else, then you're dedicated to your craft, you're dedicated to your art, and you go where that takes you. But you're happy doing what you're doing and you're not worried about well let's see I have to support a family, I've got to do this, I've got to do that. These other elements kind of force you, or at least it forced me to do things that you don't necessarily want to do, you say well this is temporary. So the Lou Rawls gig was for the most part musically rewarding. I enjoyed what I was doing. The next two professional gigs I had were show gigs. I had Raquel Welch's gig, which was a show. It was world-class musicians, but we were playing a show. And then Tony Orlando, a wonderful person to me, very good to me, but it's a show, playing the kind of music that I really didn't want to play, but again I was playing with great musicians, we were doing first-class gigs, and we were making decent bucks. So you say well, you know, if I can keep doing this, at some point maybe I'll find another professional gig that I really want to play, but if that doesn't happen, which in my case it really didn't, you're playing "Tie a Yellow Ribbon" two nights — you know, seven

nights a week, two shows a night. You know you can burn out on that stuff because you're not playing what you want to play anyway, and yet you're doing it all over the country, all over the world, and you're not home, and all the negatives take on more importance. So yeah, burn out happens. And you get to the point where you say I'd rather do something else, not necessarily rather do something other than music, but I'd rather not just keep doing this. And of course in Tony's case he went from being very, very, very busy to being not-so-busy, so the decision got to be easier. In the last year that I was with him it looked like there were twelve weeks of work scheduled for the year and prior to that it was practically the whole year. So I said well —

MR: What year was that, do you recall?

CC: I left in '85.

MR: Oh I didn't know it went that far. Do you recall why you left Lou Rawls to try those other people?

CC: Well the situation was we had some personnel changes. The type of stuff that we were doing, I wasn't that crazy about. Lou was kind of learning towards more of a disco thing and it got away from — I didn't like the songs as much. By that time — now on Lou's gig it was 52 weeks a year even if the other guys had a few days off here or there, being the musical director I did not, so a lot of times I would have to go with the boss to his home in LA and, for example, if he was going to do a recording date he would get a lot of unsolicited material and so part of my gig was to go through the boxes of tapes and little acetate records and cassettes and stuff, to try to find material that the publishing company would say well we've got some stuff here but if you've got something of your own, well great. And this is something else for aspiring songwriters, the people that check out your stuff to see if they want to record it? They listen to about ten seconds. Because you're checking out — if there's a long introduction you fast forward it because you can't be wasting your time, and you can pretty much tell right away if this is something you think you're going to listen to. So if the good stuff is in the middle of the song it never gets heard. So, but anyway, between all of that stuff if there was a TV show very often, like "The Tonight Show," when we did that, and I did that a bunch of times, I would go. The whole band wouldn't go. They would use their rhythm section. So again, guys were off, I'm over there working still. So by the end of this time I wanted to come home, I wanted to start a family, I didn't have a child at that time, and so I made a decision that the road is not what I want to do. It's not what I thought it was going to be. Let me go home.

MR: Before we sort of move on from there, is there any particular train wreck stories about any of those gigs that you want to talk about? Or great gigs?

CC: Well the train wreck gig, actually luckily we didn't get that many of them. There were one of two times, I remember with Lou Rawls our bass player was going to leave and so

we were going to be in Denver. We didn't have a bass player, and we were looking to get a permanent replacement. So there was a fella that was a bass player in Albany that I'd worked with, his son had located to Denver and apparently was working out there. Now this bass player that I knew was very, very good. And I didn't know what the son was, but I was assuming that he was a good bass player. So I got his number from Dad and called him up and said "look, we're going to be doing a gig in Denver, we need a bass player. You want to come on? If it works out you can have the gig, with Lou Rawls. And he said "yeah, you know, I'd like to try that." And he was absolutely — not only was he not very good, he was scared stiff. And so the rehearsal was just — I don't know how we're going to do this. And of course we rehearsed in the afternoon of the gig, because that's traditional. You've got a gig that starts at 8, you rehearse from 2 to 4, shower and come on. Okay. So I warned him a little ahead of time. I said "this guy's not very good so we'll just get through these two nights." So he wasn't very good. He blew just about everything. And I kept asking "turn down" so people can't hear you, and we got through two shows that night and two the next night and it was just horrible.

MR: And then you had to call Dad.

CC: Oh yes. And there were words there, you know "why did you hire this guy?" Well because, and it's just kind of a hard situation. Unless you know for sure the musician's abilities, you take a chance. I took a chance on factors that didn't actually make any difference. I never heard him play. So I just trusted. And again, you know you're in a situation where just about every musician you meet on that road circuit, they're all good. It's unusual to find somebody that's in that circuit that isn't like great. So you can come across somebody that's in there but he wasn't really in there. Okay. So that was a bad gig.

MR: Well speaking of bass players, with Jaco Pastorius, was that your choice to have him come?

CC: Absolutely. Jaco's story is really sad to me. Because he was an incredible musician. There's absolutely no doubt about that. And we used to work here, the Bachelor's Three, there were three places, Cohen's by Joe Namath and some other people, and the one in Fort Lauderdale where Jaco was a house musician in Peter Graves' band. And we played there quite a bit, I don't know, two or three times a year, whatever. And there was Jaco playing. He was just a great bass player. Everybody knew that. So this was at the same time when our bass player was going to leave after the Denver incident and we needed a bass player. So I got the bright idea to say I wonder if this guy would be interested in joining Lou's band, although the kind of stuff that Lou was doing was not where Jaco wanted to be, I was confident that he could do that with one hand tied behind his back and what would be the problem. So anyway I offered him the gig and he said yes I'd like to do that. So anyway, the bottom line is it really wasn't what he wanted to play, but he

did manage to hook up with a percussionist, Don Alias, who had lots of good connections in the jazz industry as well as the basic music industry, and he got him together with Bobby Colomby, the producer for Blood, Sweat and Tears, and so that's how the first Jaco album actually came to be. So in a way I kind of pat myself on the back by saying hey, I mean Don Alias was on my gig and they knew each other, but once they were in the same band things get tighter. And so as a result of that, I think Jaco's story kind of took on its perspective. What's sad about it is when I met Jaco he was all into running barefoot on the beach and drinking orange juice and he was a health nut and all of that. And as time went on the psychosis that he had, which is well documented now, became more and more obvious and he really had mental problems and then couple that with drug abuse and eventually he met his unfortunate demise that way, and that's sad. But I do feel I had a little something to do with his getting where it was. It would have happened anyway, I firmly believe that somebody with that kind of immense talent and something to say, you know, it would have happened. It just happened to happen that way.

MR: Yeah. It's nice to be part of his story in a positive way. And I forgot that you had Don Alias on that gig. He was a great guy too. And then you brought Rick [Montalbano] into the band, is that right?

CC: Yeah, that was my first official act. When the piano player/conductor left and they said okay they want to make you the musical director, of course we've got to find a piano player. And I said "got the guy."

MR: Oh okay.

CC: So I almost, without even asking permission from Lou, I said "I've already got a piano player." And he said "oh, okay."

MR: Yeah okay. I remember that specifically.

CC: Oh yeah?

MR: I had moved to Rome and I hadn't been there that long, and Rick was the first guy I got to know. And I remember when he got that call. He was very excited. And I went over to his house and he was like "I can't talk to you now, I've got this stuff here." He always had his Fender Rhodes you know. That's cool. So when you came back here, then you thought well what am I going to do here? Am I going to teach? Was that like forming in your mind, that you could become —

CC: Oh always. When I was in high school I was asked by a music store to do some teaching, and so I've been teaching since I was like 14 or 15. You know, after school, there on Saturdays, that kind of stuff. And then even with, well with Lou's gig somewhat, but I basically shut my studio down for the years I was with Lou. But with Tony's gig, Tony would work a couple of weeks and then take a couple of weeks off. He had to rest his voice. He didn't really have a trained singing style. So we'd work two weeks, and then

two weeks we didn't work. And that kind of went on for several years, like clockwork. And so while I was home I would teach. So I kept my studio going and I'd just tell people "okay your next lesson will be such and such a date." So it was always still there. And I realized that when I would get off the road I could still use that as the basis and do some local playing, and that I did. The local playing scene has gotten leaner and leaner, as you are well aware. But then I spent more of my time concentrating on building my studio.

MR: And now, from my observation, you take this very seriously.

CC: Oh yeah.

MR: Like, you're unlikely to cancel a lesson so you can play a gig. Right?

CC: True. Yeah. It's a commitment to me. I mean not only I feel the students are committed if you schedule lessons with me, you've got to be here. You take a class, you make the class. At the same time, if I'm always dumping them because I've got a chance to play a gig, that's not fair to them. Now way way back I used to have certain people come in and sub for me, and say "well you will have a lesson, it'll be with" so-and-so. And it worked in some cases. In other cases it didn't work so well and they'd say "well I didn't really like what this guy did," or whatever. So I figured okay, if you're going to have them make a commitment to you, you make a commitment to them.

MR: And I think it works out good locally, it's like an event when you play out. Well I'm telling you it is.

CC: It's lucky that it worked out that way, because again, being a burn out, now when I play the gigs that I play now, it's stuff that I want to play and I enjoy it and it's great. But it's nice to have people out there, all right? I remember one time we played this one room, it's closed now, The Bearded Dolphin. And I think we played it maybe five or six weekends in a row. And the last weekend that we played there there were like two or three guys at the bar watching a basketball game, and the band. That was it. And one of the guys came over and said "do you want to hold it down, we're trying to watch the game." And we said we're playing too much. People aren't coming out. So we made a conscious decision to only play once every eight or ten weeks or something like that, so we really would enjoy what we were doing and maybe people will come. And that's worked out very well for us. When we do play we get a decent sized audience, and we look forward to the next gig rather than saying "are you ready to do it again, and again, and again." Maybe it shouldn't be that way but it is for me. If I've got to play five nights a week again, no matter what I'm playing, I don't know if I'd like that as much.

MR: Do you feel you've kept up with technology and teaching pedagogy as much as you would like?

CC: Luckily it kind of fell on me. I've been doing a lot more — when Midi first came out I jumped into that and that was kind of fun for me because even though I'm not a

keyboardist I could set patterns, I could do things, I could write arrangements and hear them, and I was teaching some students how to do that. Recording-wise we got everything happening in the studios for that stuff. The programs that I use where you can like actually do ear training on these programs, there's guitar-specific programs that we can use, so it's been a big help to me. I don't know how we'd get along teaching-wise — you know the old days you've got two folding chairs and a music stand and you'd do it that way. If somebody wants to hear something, oh YouTube, there it is. "You need to slow that down, hang on, I'll take my scratch pad program — here's the lick. Going too fast? Try it this way." We didn't have those things. So it's been very useful.

MR: Okay. What if I came to you as a student and said "Carmen, when should I use a symmetric diminished scale?"

CC: I would say "what have you been reading?"

MR: I ask that because it's been asked of me and I didn't know how to respond.

CC: I have a book called *The Grimoire*, *The Guitar Grimoire*. And I didn't know this before, but grimoire is an ancient word which means a manual, a magician's manual. I mean you open it up and you have all these spells. That kind of stuff. And it is hundreds of diagrams, all over the neck of the guitar, and notation, on all these various scales and their names. You know, the Arabian scale, the Hungarian sharp two scale, I mean these things go on and on and on and on. And there are a lot of people that take great pride in saying okay here's a scale and we'll make this change and that change and now we'll give it this name and we'll do the modes of those scales, which on guitar translates to seven different finger patterns, so even a major scale would consist of seven different notes, now is 49 different locations in the first octave alone, so you learn all these patterns. Then you try to tell the guy, "where's the C?" "Oh wait a minute. Hang on. I'll tell you in a minute." And he'll locate it. So again, the guitar is a graphic animal and you have to approach it in a different way. But what these guys have done is come up with all of these variations on the scale until you can use this scale over this chord, and this over that and this over that. So in a way there's a certain understandable value to that. But on the other hand you can't just learn a catalogue of scales and say "okay, this is going to be Enigmatic scale." "Right, well how do I use it?" "Well let's see how somebody else used it." And you find that, at least for me, it comes out to be building melodies. And you build melodies based on active notes, notes that are not in the chord but have a little bit, of a tension that takes you someplace; and on passive notes, which are nice resolve notes, and it depends on what you want to create. So if you want to create a whole bunch of active notes then you can play a scale a half-step below where it's supposed to be and say "isn't that cool?" Then you have to look at it and say does that mean anything? Am I playing something just because it's tense, or am I playing something because I want to

have a little tension which takes me to a nice resolve. So you have to start thinking about how you want to do things. So I'd say a lot of academics in music I have found is learning a lot of names, spitting them back on the test, and then, without a full understanding of what those elements are supposed to do musically they're meaningless. You get people that just use these scales and they don't really know why and they can't make any music out of them. So I tell them "if you want to learn the names, that's cool. But I want you to listen to what are you playing, why are you playing it, how does that fit and where are you going with it. Is it something you played before. Are you playing that motif backwards, what are you doing?" I get them to analyze what they're playing and how they do it.

MR: I'm beginning to see why all the guitar players in town say "you have to go to Carmen." That's great, what you just said. Do you ever tell a student that — do you ever use the word "mistake" when you're listening to a student try to improvise?

CC: If it's actually a mistake. I try to make a distinction between did you mean to play this note or did you just hit it wrong. If you hit it wrong, that's a mistake. If you meant to play it then let's talk about why you did that.

MR: And what came next?

CC: Yeah.

MR: Nice. So let's say I had a son and I sent him to you and he really wanted to be a professional musician, but his talent level was medium. Do you have those kind of situations?

CC: Yeah.

MR: And how have you learned to — what have you learned to say?

CC: Okay. If they're at a point where they have to decide what they want to do after high school, I get a lot of that. I say okay, apply to some colleges, get your audition material ready, see if you get in. If you get in the school, okay, and if you're going to go for a performance degree or a music ed degree or whatever it is, try it for a semester or two semesters. If you're not sure or if you can't get into something on a higher level, go to OCC if they'll still let you in, or some of the community colleges that have got a basic music program, and see how you like it. You're going to find out an awful lot about how well you do compared to the guy sitting next to you. Sometimes — there is a place in Los Angeles called MIT, Musician's Institute of Technology. It used to be GIT, Guitar Institute of Technology. And they have a degree program now, but originally it was a one-year inclusive program of just playing, lessons, recording sessions, going on a short tour with some of the bands, learning what it's like to really be in the business. And some of my students went and came back after completing the course, and said "you know I really figured that I can't do this thing professionally. These guys are too good. I don't

stand a chance. They're just incredibly excellent." I know there are people that have gone that still maintained their music thing but they realized if I'm going to be trying to get these jobs like the guys in Los Angeles or New York, if they're that good, the other half is you don't know the right people, because a lot of it is a very closed society. These kids grew up with each other. Kids that went to Hollywood High School and their fathers are producers. They're going to get the gigs. So anyway basically I tell them if you're interested in becoming a musician you've got to go to school. You've got to go to a music school where other people are interested in the same thing as you are. You network that way. You find out how good you are and how good you're not. And you kind of let the world show them what they need to do rather than have me try to tell them.

MR: That sounds like good advice. Let them find out on their own. And then they won't hold it against their parents too if Mom and Dad say you know what, you really need to go into geology.

CC: And of course they can't blame you as a teacher either, well you told me I was good enough or you told me I wasn't good enough. No I say hey, go try it. If you can do it, you'll know. If you can't well — I used to take the approach where I'd try to talk them out of it because I'd say "you don't know how hard it is out there, you don't want to do this." And if I could talk them out of it, and they say well I've decided to do something else, then I'd say well I'm glad you did because if I can talk you out of it you don't stand a chance anyway. So I used to try that approach. But now I think I've found the other way. Encourage them but it doesn't take long — if they can make it past the first year in school there's a good chance they'll stay. And if they don't —

MR: Do you encourage them to develop other skills besides just being a player?

CC: Such as?

MR: Finaleing, arranging.

CC: Oh absolutely.

MR: All that stuff.

CC: Yeah. And it's so easy because I learn a lot about what I know now about musical technology from these kids. No they help me. If I'm trying to do something "oh Mr. Caramanica do this." "Oh thank you, I didn't know." Yeah. So there is no problem saying you should get this program or that program or let's work with this thing, they just take right to it.

MR: Sometimes you hear people talking about how Utica/Central New York, spawned many great musicians. Do you have a feeling that this area used to be a nice climate for musicians?

CC: Absolutely. And I can't tell you why, but it goes back to the 30's and 40's I guess. And from my era, Vince Falcone, the pianist from Syracuse that became Frank Sinatra's

conductor, and Tony Bennett's conductor; there was a guy named Torrie Zito of the Zito brothers, Torrie, Art and Ronnie. Ronnie is a drummer and when he was either 18 or 19 he was playing a gig with my former employer Jimmy Cavallo at the Beeches in Rome. Another story, this guy was in the main room with Bobby Darin, and it was the same situation, they heard this drummer and he became Bobby Darin's drummer. Took him right out of Jimmy's band. Artie Zito was a bass player. I don't think he did much outside of Utica but he was well respected; and Torrie Zito was a famous arranger, also a Utica guy. Boy it goes on and on. Everybody, Sal Nistico from Syracuse, the Mangione brothers out of Rochester but still part of the Central New York situation, Chic Esposito, Sal Amico, the Albericos.

MR: And they mostly end with vowels.

CC: You noticed that.

MR: I did.

CC: That's part of the magic I think.

MR: You guys used to tell me I needed to change my last name when we played at The Beeches because I was the only — well you know literally I do have a vowel.

CC: Yeah that's true.

MR: But it's not the right kind of vowel. It's been a fascinating conversation. Any recording, studio recording memories you've had of doing things — let me rephrase. If you listen to the oldies station now these days, do you ever hear yourself with any of the Lou Rawls stuff, Tony Orlando, do you ever hear stuff you played on?

CC: Well there was a recording that I did with Tony, which it's a surprise because you almost never hear this thing, but Tony was trying to get into, and this was not good timing, into disco, while disco was dying. And so they made this disco recording and I had just joined the band. And for some reason they thought it was magic, he had to have me on this recording somewhere. And the road musicians don't usually play on the recording, they have studio musicians who know how to make records rather than guys that play out. That's just the thing in Los Angeles. But in any event so he brought me in on this arrangement to be a soloist on a song called "Sweets for my Sweet/Sugar for my Honey," an old three chord rock song. And they wanted me to play some lead fills and a little solo in the middle of this thing and I was like "great, three chords." And there wasn't much for me to do to get in the way of everything. So but anyway I played this thing and they thought it was so wonderful that, you know, okay, this is going to be a hit. Well I don't really know how the record industry works, because we were on the road and Tony comes running into the band's dressing room and said "you're not going to believe this, we entered the charts at number 42." "What entered the charts?" "Sweets for my Sweet." I said "entered the charts at 42?" Now what's Billboard, 300 or something? It's the top

300? How does it enter the charts at 42? "Oh it's very scientific. Very scientific." Okay. Fine. So a couple of issues later it's number thirty-something. 36 or 37. I said "you're in the top 40." I said great, I'm on a top 40 record. I hated it, but, I'm on a top 40 record. And then a couple of issues later he comes in and says "they pulled it." I said "what do you mean they pulled it?" He said "it's no longer in Billboard." Out of 300 it was like 30 something, what happened? He said "oh it's very scientific, very scientific." So I don't get it, how they got it in and when they pulled it out. So what I did here was all of a sudden was I did hear "Sweets for my Sweet" wait a minute, that's me, and I could hear it on the radio, and I heard my little three notes, hey that was me, I did that. Another story which is backwards, when I was with Lou, he was going to do the theme soundtrack for a blacksploitation movie. There were a series of these things out in the 70's. And this one was a series of stories based on a character who they called "Nigger Charlie."

MR: Wow.

CC: You've heard of this? Oh. Well anyway there were several of these movies. One of them, this particular one, was called "The Soul of Nigger Charlie," it was a western, right, in which the hero was a black man who had problems. Okay. So there were several songs that Lou was going to record and one of them was called "Sunshine Day." Well this was arranged by a guy named Don Costa, who was a very well-known musical director and arranger for the movies, and it was done at MGM studios in Los Angeles, and I was brought in as a guitar soloist, right? So again, they were going to do doing the chart and then the section in there where I had to do some solo work. All right. So they bring in my stuff, and it's next to, oh I can't remember who the guys were but it'd be people like Larry Carlton and, you know, all these famous studio musicians are there, Tommy Tedesco, and all these guys would be there, and then it would be this guitar player, so they'd move over or then they'd go in the other room or something like that, and there was a big orchestra with the movie showing up on the screen and all this, and so we go through and we play the thing and we did a couple of takes, and it was fine, and Costa — oh and after I played my solos they would listen to the playback and Costa comes back up and he steps on this little podium and he says "that's a wrap. And I want to thank the guitar player here for putting on that thing" — and the whole orchestra starts to applaud. And I said oh my God, I'm getting applause from the studio orchestra, isn't that cool? So I can't wait to hear this thing in a movie. So a few weeks later we're playing in Boston and there on the movie theater, the marquee, "The Soul of Nigger Charlie." Oh great, I'm going to go hear myself in a movie. So I went to the movie theater and there it is, and I begin to hear my opening lick [scats] that's me playing that guitar part. And when it come to my big solo, they had placed girls' voices over my solo, so you could kind of hear a little faint guitar in the background, but you heard girls singing [scats]. So the

lesson learned there is that once you've done a work for hire, they can do whatever they want with it. They can use it, they can not use it, whatever. So I said jeez, it was a good solo, wasn't it? It was a good experience, it just didn't come out in public that way. So I got myself on the movie screen and on the radio.

MR: Do you ever get any checks from any of that work? "The Tonight Show" or that stuff?

CC: Yeah. Not in a long time. I do remember I got a check for, I think it was a "Midnight Special" that we did, and it was something like 38 cents. It came out of the "Midnight Special" and let's see, I left Lou in what, '76. So it had to be somewhere between '72 and '76 that we did that show. And this thing came, I don't know, twenty years later or whatever. Apparently it was a new use check for a check for a "Midnight Special" that had aired in Japan or something. And the musician's union kept track of it and they sent me a check for 38 cents. I think I cashed it. I'm not sure.

MR: I bet you looked at it a couple of times to make sure the decimal point was not —

CC: 38 cents and not —

MR: How funny. Anything on your little list that I didn't ask you about?

CC: No I think we did pretty good. I do have — back to the recording thing, with Tony Orlando we did a TV show called "Tony Orlando's First Special." It was for NBC. And the director was Alan Thicke. And so we did the show and I had a feature, a guitar feature. Well anyway, longer story, it was kind of a Spanish type thing on the song "Up on the Roof," all right, and they had dancers and all this stuff they were going to do. So we did a pre-record in the studio and again I'm doing all these fancy jamming things over this one section. And they decided they were going to use that track. And I said okay, that's fine. And then they'd say "oh by the way, be there early, you'll be in make-up, you've got to be in make-up. Well yeah, they're going to put this van on this rooftop set and you'll be playing your instruments." And I thought good, we just spent a couple of hours in the studio messing around and I'm improvising Spanish type licks all over this piece and I'm going to be there with my guitar, am I going to look like an idiot like playing something that's not in sync with the music? So I asked the director, or the engineer rather, can you give me a quick cassette of what we just did?" "Oh sure." So he made me a cassette of it, and then I took it back to the hotel room and I practiced with the cassette, trying to remember what I did, and memorize my finger patterns. So this was wonderful. So then when it came time for the shoot I mentioned to somebody, I've got my solo memorized, so if you need to get anywhere near my hands I'll be right. Well this guy went running to the director and told him. And the director made an announcement that I was in sync with the music. Ah, this is great. So out comes Tony Orlando with his costume, and he says "you want to hear something great? My guitar player spent all night learning his solo so that he would be in sync for the camera. Isn't that dedication?" I'd

been on the gig for about two weeks. So the other guys in the band they're looking at me like you apple polisher. Not why I did it. I just wanted to make sure that if I was down here and the music was up here that the guys at home wouldn't look at me and say "you didn't play that" or whatever. But anyway so I did that, and that came off okay. But then I went home to Utica, and about two days later Alan Thicke called up our musical director, Reg Powell, and said look, Norman Lear is going to be doing a show, he's got a pilot, and it's called "Different Strokes." And we need a band to come in quick and cut this thing. Now you guys just did the show and you're very good, do you think you could get together and come in later on this afternoon and do this show? And he said "let me see call everybody and see if I can find them." Now meanwhile I'm in Utica, and the other guys all live in LA. So they were able to go in and do the "Different Strokes" theme song and they said well it's on spec. We don't know if the network is going to pick it up or whatever. So we can either pay you for the session, or you can do it for free and we'll put you on speculation. And they said "well what's the deal on spec?" "Well every 13 weeks you get scale, and then each day that it's played out of that 13 weeks, you get scale per day." And so it's every 13 weeks full session, plus a daily rate on those kind of things. Now naturally I'm in Utica so I don't get to be part of this thing. All right? So obviously the show got picked up, "Different Strokes" ran for what, ten years or whatever the thing was, and these guys got residual checks every 13 weeks the show ran, plus new use, plus overseas, I mean they're probably still getting checks. It came out to some nice money. But you had to be in Los Angeles. That's part of the thing, it's something else for people that want to be a career musician, now it's different with the Internet, but for situations like that, you've got to be where it was happening.

MR: Right. You have to be able to show up in a hurry and take advantage of the opportunities and network and everything else. Wow. Well I've really enjoyed this conversation.

CC: Why thank you. I had a good time.

MR: You answered a lot of the things that I had wondered about you and I want to thank you because I've stolen licks from you over the years. And you know, I remember going way back now to the Beeches where we started, I remember being fascinated because a person would come up and say "Can you guys play 'Behind Closed Doors'" or some song like that, and you would look at Rick and say what key, and you guys would just play it. And I remember there was times when you guys would get to the bridge and you might not really know it but you would make one up. You'd make up a bridge. I don't even know if you would remember that.

CC: No.

MR: But you did. And it would make musical sense because you would follow a typical bridge pattern, come back to the A section, and I just thought boy, that is really good.

CC: Ah, the street musician.

MR: Yeah. And I guess it goes back to learning stuff by ear and listening to the radio.

CC: Well when you have to eat on it you learn how to do that stuff.

MR: You know you told me something once and I said to myself wow, I remember saying wow. Because you said music is great until you have to make a living at it. I think I may be paraphrasing you. But it was a very on-target, practical piece of advice.

CC: Yeah. Something we learned the hard way.

MR: Yeah. Well any students that are out there now performing that you gave some knowledge to? Any guys from Utica that sort of have made it in the biz?

CC: Well the obvious, I had the pleasure of teaching Joe Bonamassa for a summer. And I never take any credit for his success or his ability because he did it by himself. And by the time his dad brought him to me he was like eleven years old and said "I want you to give him some direction." After we played for ten minutes I said "he's got his direction, we're just going to play together." And so he would come in and we'd jam once a week and I'd tell him how great he was and made no effort — I mean I tried to just tell him a little bit of this and a little bit of that, but you could see that he was already in the formative years and he knew what he wanted to do, and he was a very polite kid, he was very nice and treated me with a great deal of respect. But there was no way that anybody — now I'm sure he had a lot of teachers and a lot of people over the years that take credit for his ability. But it was all him. Especially — even after he got his butt kicked when Bloodline got — whatever you say — they stopped working and they lost their record deal and all this stuff, he, by himself, regrouped, got himself a little recording set-up in his bedroom and started writing, singing — he never wanted to sing a note, it was not the thing he wanted to do. He said I've got to learn to sing. He learned to sing, went down to New York by himself, knocking on doors, hey I was in Bloodline, I did this, I did that, looking for a producer. By the time he got to Tom Dowd, who produced the album that really did something, he did it on his own. So nobody takes credit for this man's success. I'm proud to say I was that much in the background there, but it's a success.

MR: Yeah. Well, thank you for your time today. It's been really fascinating. All right?

CC: Yeah.